that LTTE operatives had arrived in speedboats to take Sivarasan back to Jaffna. A house-to-house search was carried out in Rameswaram and Dhanushkodi. All the jetties were closed in the region to check any boat sailing out.

Around 9 a.m., the local police alerted the naval ship with a message that said a Yamaha speedboat named *Karainagar* with multiple engines was seen speeding towards Casuarina Grove with militants on board. The ship altered its course and headed in its direction. It could not spot any such vessel, though. A naval chopper that was carrying Kanth and Verma to Rameswaram picked up the radio message and also looked for the speedboat. It was shortly found abandoned in the shallow waters near the grove. But there was no one in it. A passport-size photo of Sivarasan was found in the boat, indicating that it had indeed come on a rescue mission.

The police sent out a red alert in the areas where there were chances of the militants mixing with the local crowd. Among the hundreds of calls the SIT received, one call that should have been responded to with alacrity was ignored. And that proved to be the SIT's undoing. A woman called twice and said that Sivarasan and Sundaram were her neighbours. The caller didn't divulge her name and address, but she did tell them the name of the locality she lived in—Kodungaiyur in north Madras. In her second call, she asked the SIT to meet her at a restaurant in the area, after which she could lead them to the house where Sivarasan had been staying. For reasons best known to the SIT, the call was ignored for want of a specific address, though the caller had given the address of the restaurant where the SIT could meet her. The SIT insisted on the address of the house where the caller claimed Sivarasan had been living.[15]

The caller was Esylen Mantel. She and her family lived in the house right next to the assassination hit squad in Everready Colony, Kodungaiyur. Had the SIT acted fast that day, it might even have caught the entire gang. The house was Sivarasan's base, from where he kept in touch with Jaffna through the UHF set. The Mantels were the only neighbours the gang used to interact with. However, it had all come to a halt when Sivarasan's photograph was published. Mantel had asked the landlord of the house,